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THA 214: Fundamentals of Script Writing - Structure, Character and Dialogue

Write a producible short play and learn to revise it

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 200L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Why this pack exists

Playwriting is a craft with repeatable techniques: premise, conflict, character want, escalation and resolution. This pack gives you a scene-by-scene method, dialogue exercises, formatting conventions and a revision checklist, ending with a ten-minute play brief you can actually complete.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Turn a premise into a dramatic conflict with stakes.
- Build a scene that has a clear want, obstacle and change.
- Write dialogue that performs character rather than explaining it.
- Format a script professionally and revise it through structured readings.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Premise, conflict, stakes

A play needs someone who wants something they cannot easily get.

- Premise: the situation in one sentence, including the disruption.
- Protagonist: the character who drives the action.
- Objective: what they want now, in this scene.
- Obstacle: the person or condition blocking them.
- Stakes: what happens if they fail.
- Theme emerges from the argument the play stages, not from a speech.

Scenes that turn

A scene earns its place by changing something.

- Enter late, leave early: start after the small talk and cut before the resolution.
- Give each character a distinct tactic, not just a distinct opinion.
- Escalate: each beat should raise cost or narrow options.
- Use subtext: characters rarely say exactly what they want.
- End the scene on a shift in power, knowledge or decision.
- Read dialogue aloud to catch lines no human would say.

> **Show, do not explain**
> If a character announces the theme, cut the line and let the action carry it. Audiences trust what they witness.

Format and revision

Standard formatting signals professionalism and speeds rehearsal.

- Scene headings, character names in capitals, dialogue, stage directions in italics or brackets.
- Keep stage directions minimal and physical.
- Number pages for rehearsal and timing.
- Hold a table read and mark where attention drops.
- Revise for clarity, not cleverness: cut ten percent.
- Keep drafts labelled with dates and version numbers.

A play is a machine for producing events

Beginning writers describe. Produced writers make things happen. The unit of a play is not the line but the event: something changes between the start and end of a scene, and the audience can name what changed. If a scene could be removed without altering anything later, it is not a scene; it is a conversation.

Structure in the practical sense is the arrangement of those changes so that each one makes the next one necessary. The traditional three-act shape and the five-act shape are descriptions of that pressure, not recipes. What matters is that the protagonist wants something, tries, fails in a way that raises the cost, and is finally forced to act in a way they would have avoided at the start.

Write the spine before the dialogue. One page: who wants what, who or what blocks it, what is at risk if they fail, and what the last image is. If you cannot write that page, no amount of dialogue will save the script, because you do not yet know what the scenes are for.

Dialogue is behaviour with words

People rarely say what they mean, and characters should not either. Dialogue works when each speaker is pursuing an objective and using language as an instrument - to persuade, to deflect, to wound, to test. Write the objective above each scene and check that every exchange serves it.

Cut the exposition. Audiences accept information they overhear but resist information they are told. Let the facts arrive as a by-product of an argument: a character mentions the rent because they are angry about it, not because the audience needs to know. Two lines of conflict can carry a page of backstory.

Read every line aloud. Speech that looks fine on the page often reveals itself as unsayable: too many subordinate clauses, tongue-twisting consonant clusters, or a rhythm that no human breath supports. Cut ten per cent of the words in every speech and the scene usually improves.

> **The rewrite rule**
> A first draft is material, not a script. Plan to write three: one to find the story, one to fix the structure, one to polish the language.

Format, producibility and collaboration

Standard play format is functional: character names in capitals at the left margin, dialogue beneath, stage directions in italics or brackets indented, act and scene headings, and a character list at the front. Nobody awards marks for typography, but a script that is hard to read will be read badly.

Producibility is a discipline. Count your locations, your cast, your costume changes and your effects. A script that needs twelve actors, five sets and a live animal will not be staged by a student company, however good the writing. Constraints often improve the work: a single room forces conflict into language.

A script is a blueprint for other people. The director, designer, actors and stage manager will all make decisions from your pages, so include only what they cannot invent themselves: who speaks, what is necessary for the action, and what would otherwise be misunderstood. Directing from the page ("she looks at him meaningfully, remembering her father") removes the actor's work and usually reads as amateur.

OUTLINE ARCHIVE

Session record: THA 214

2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Year demarcation matters: a course code that existed in 2018 may have been renumbered, merged or dropped by 2019, and the department now also runs a film track. Read the year label before you rely on a code. The current entry below is a compiled map - take it to your course rep or the departmental office and confirm it before registration.

2018 — Archived course description — ARCHIVED

- THA 214 Fundamentals of Script Writing
- Scripting and plot devices, characterisation, theme and language in creating a dramatic script
- Graded exercises developing individual and group scripts

Source: unizik.edu.ng - Theatre & Film Studies course description (page dated 31 May 2018; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2019 — Archived programme listing — ARCHIVED

- THA 214 Fundamentals of Script Writing, 3 credits, second semester, 200 level
- Later script courses: THA 322 Script Analysis and THA 332 Principles of Adaptation and Improvisation
- Writing sits within the dramaturgy stress area alongside directing

What changed: The 2019 listing adds a 300-level script analysis and adaptation sequence after the 200-level writing course.

Source: arts.unizik.edu.ng - Theatre Arts programme and course map (page dated 18 Oct 2019; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2025/2026 — Compiled working map — CURRENT WORKING MAP

- Fundamentals of script writing remains the 200-level dramaturgy core
- Expect a portfolio assessment: premise, scene work and a revised draft
- Ask whether your cohort writes for stage, screen or both

Source: Compiled by ZikShare from the archived 2018 and 2019 departmental pages plus the published stress areas; this is a working map, not an official handout (retrieved 2026-10-22)

Archive means: this records what a public departmental page listed in that year. It is not a guarantee of the current curriculum, and ZikShare is not affiliated with UNIZIK.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Building a ten-minute play from one want

You need a complete short play for assessment. Here is a workable construction method.

1. Choose one want with a deadline: a student needs a signature before an office closes.
2. Give the want an obstacle with power: the official is the mother of the student's ex-partner.
3. Set the stakes: without the signature, a scholarship is lost.
4. Start late - at the moment the request is refused, not at the walk to the office.
5. Escalate twice: first a reasonable argument, then a threat, then an offer the student cannot afford.
6. End on a decision that costs something, and cut the explanation of what it cost.

> **What to carry forward**
> One want, one obstacle, two escalations, one costly decision. That is a complete short play.

2. Turning a bad scene into a scene

Your scene has two characters discussing whether to attend a party. It is dull. Diagnose and repair.

1. Name what changes: nothing, so there is no scene.
2. Ask what each character wants in the scene and whether the wants conflict.
3. Introduce a cost: one of them has already told a lie about the party.
4. Cut the first 30 seconds where they agree.
5. Make the refusal happen on a specific line and let the other character react with an action rather than a speech.
6. End before the argument resolves, so the next scene has somewhere to go.

> **What to carry forward**
> If nobody wants anything incompatible, you have written an interview, not a scene.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Explain the function of conflict in dramatic structure and distinguish it from argument.

15 marks

1. Define conflict as incompatible objectives, not raised voices.
2. Show how conflict generates events and therefore structure.
3. Distinguish argument (a form conflict may take) from conflict itself.
4. Give an example of a quiet scene with high conflict.
5. Conclude that structure is the arrangement of unresolved incompatibilities.

Q2. Why should a writer avoid directing the actor in stage directions?

10 marks

1. Explain the division of labour: the script supplies action and speech, the production supplies interpretation.
2. Show how over-written directions pre-empt the actor and director.
3. Distinguish necessary directions (entrances, business required by plot) from emotional instructions.
4. Note the practical cost: a script that cannot be staged flexibly is less likely to be produced.

> **Where marks are lost**
> Confusing stage directions that make the plot possible with directions that dictate feeling.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Event. A change in the situation of a scene that the audience can name.

Objective. What a character is trying to achieve in a scene.

Obstacle. The force or person preventing the objective, which generates conflict.

Stakes. What is lost if the character fails.

Spine. The one-page statement of want, obstacle, risk and ending that organises the draft.

Beat. A unit of change within a scene, marked by a shift in tactic or power.

Exposition. Background information the audience needs, best delivered as a by-product of action.

Subtext. Meaning carried under the spoken words.

Reversal. A moment where the action turns against the protagonist's expectation.

Climax. The point of highest pressure where the central incompatibility must resolve.

Producibility. The practical feasibility of staging a script with available cast, space and budget.

Rewriting. The structured revision of a draft for story, structure and language.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Spine

Story before dialogue.

- Write a one-page spine for two ideas.
- Choose the one with higher stakes.
- Outline five events.

Week 2 - First draft

Getting to the end.

- Write the draft without editing.
- Mark the event in every scene.
- Read it aloud once.

Week 3 - Structure

Cutting and escalating.

- Delete any scene with no event.
- Add one escalation in act two.
- Check the ending costs something.

Week 4 - Language

Dialogue and format.

- Cut ten per cent of every speech.
- Read with two actors.
- Reformat to standard script layout.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Any practical playwriting guide covering structure, conflict and rewriting.
- Two published short plays to study how quickly a scene establishes want and obstacle.
- Your department's script submission guidelines for format and length.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. What is the difference between an objective and an obstacle?

Answer: The objective is what a character wants in the scene; the obstacle is what blocks them from getting it.

2. Why is subtext important in dialogue?

Answer: It creates tension between what is said and what is meant, giving actors something to play and audiences something to interpret.

3. What does 'enter late, leave early' mean?

Answer: Begin a scene after the routine preliminaries and end before the obvious resolution, keeping only dramatically necessary action.

4. How should stage directions be written?

Answer: Sparingly, in the present tense, focused on visible physical action rather than inner emotion.

5. Give one test for a weak line of dialogue.

Answer: If it could be spoken by any character in the play without changing meaning, it is not yet character-specific.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Write three premises with a clear disruption.
- [ ] Outline a ten-minute play in beats.
- [ ] Draft one scene of no more than three pages.
- [ ] Read it aloud with two coursemates.
- [ ] Cut ten percent of the lines after the reading.
- [ ] Format the script correctly with a title page.
- [ ] Submit a second draft with a short revision note.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date: